Realism: The Rise of Modern Art and its Societal Reflections

Ward Al Halabi and Ghaith Maisour

Abstract

This article is an examination of modern art and how it has changed from the late 19th century up until now – mainly 20th century. It shows how art has emerged as a revolutionary departure from traditional forms and was largely influenced by political, economic, and rapid social changes. The history field of art has significantly developed over the past centuries and this article highlights how it has played a huge role in constant

[illegible] studies and diverse fine culture. Films, which emphasized personal depth, and jazz, which organized life and sound, both made substantial contributions in expressing social frustration. A [illegible] language that [illegible] profile and tone, music attained a wide range of [illegible] and [illegible] cross-cultural exchange. Notable jazz trumpeter, composer, and singer Louis Armstrong exemplified how [illegible] and lifted people.

Conclusion:

African American [illegible] and music expression [illegible] culture [illegible] the United States Representative People like Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, and Duke Ellington challenged [illegible] prejudices and worked for social improvement through literature, music, visual arts, and performance. The Great Migration occurred as the response for the movement, which created a space for Black students and artists to flourish and laid the foundation for the Civil Rights Movement. Art and culture are powerful change agents, as evidenced by the way its legacy continues to inspire creativity, resilience, and pride in African American heritage.

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This article is an examination of modern art and how it has changed from the late 19th century up until now – early 21st century. It shows how art has emerged as a revolutionary departure from traditional forms and was heavily influenced by political, economic, and cultural issues. The history field of art has significantly developed over the past centuries and this article highlights how it has played a huge role in [illegible]

[illegible] Furthermore, it also [illegible] the impact of the world on art and [illegible] how the global [illegible] also had a role in changing modern art into the [illegible] we all know now. The study also considers [illegible] like the [illegible] Renaissance, which, in the face of economic [illegible], sought to [illegible] a [illegible] [illegible] connections. To add, this [illegible] [illegible] modern art has served as both a [illegible] and a critique of rapidly evolving world. Moreover, starting from the late 19th century, marks a transformative era in the history of human expression. This dynamic shift from traditional artistic conventions reflects a profound engagement with the rapidly evolving world. This paper explores the rise of modern art, its foundation underpinnings, and its enduring impact on society, offering a comprehensive view of its evolution as a lexicon of human [illegible], creativity, and thought.

Introduction:

Modern art has been in [illegible] since the late 19th century up to the present day, representing a shift in how art is created, perceived, and understood. In general, modern art serves as a challenge of viewers' perceptions aesthetically and intellectually to question society, culture, and engage in complex social issues. Its reach is unparalleled styles, abstract representations, and innovations, pop art represents more than an individual perspective of the artist but changes with larger themes across society. These works often serve as a collection or critique of pop culture, which Picasso's "Guernica" speaks to, or as Andy Warhol's demonstration of consumerism through pop art. Modern art holds up a mirror to the values, conflicts, and dreams of society ("A Brief History of Modern Art").

Modern art is also a reflection and critique of society, whether it be the upholding or questioning of the cultural, political or social systems ("American Representation Movement Overview"). In this sense, it would be hard to describe modern art as a [illegible] medium in which artists reflect upon and provide critiques of the human organisation.

Origins of Modern Art:

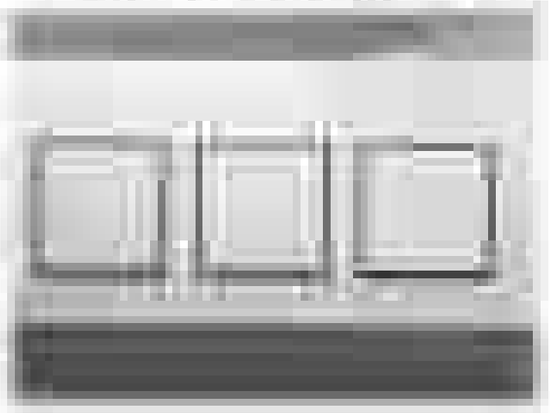
The origin of modern art is traditionally traced to the mid to late 19th century, representing a notable change from traditional artistic conventions. This period was known for its rapid changes in technological, social, and political advancements as well as a shift in philosophical thoughts. Art historians credit these conditions because of new generations of artists challenging the "traditional way" of art, further could explore new ways of self-expression, often highlighting raw, centered aspects of human life and social issues. To add, it also was not a sudden or a response to the rapid societal changes brought about by industrialization, urbanization, and technological advancements. Modern art failed the classical style that had dominated European art for centuries.

Socio-Political Backdrop: How History Shaped Modern Art?

[illegible] modern art owes a great deal to the concepts pioneered by artists such as the cubists of the 19th and 20th centuries, challenging reality and the very way in which art was produced. As artists wrestled with, in spite of [illegible] conventions, how to represent a rapidly changing world, they sought inspiration and intellectual discussion of the time. Modernism's progress was not a linear trajectory, but a response to deep societal changes. As society changed through industrialization, wars, and economic upheaval, art became the way for humanity to express its commercial and moderate. And with each great historical period, there came intellectual responses, shaping the diverse styles of modern art.

1. The Industrial Revolution and Shifting Societal Values

The Industrial Revolution in the late 18th to early 19th century was a period of immense change. Factories sprang up, cities grew rapidly, and class dynamics widened. This backdrop led to the birth of impressionism, notably the Claude Monet and Pierre-Auguste Renoir period lasting often 50, focusing on capturing the "impression" of a scene rather than strict realism (St-Art). These paintings often depicted fleeting moments—sunlit lakes, crowded streets, or outdoor cafes—reflecting the fast-paced nature of industrial life.



By the early 20th century, Expressionism emerged, with artists like Edvard Munch and Ernst Ludwig Kirchner who prioritized the psychological aspect of experience and emotion. Works like The Scream exemplified this, employing distorted forms and vibrant colors to evoke feelings of anxiety. Cubism, in turn, became a way to deconstruct reality, showcasing the industrial speed and multiplicity. Picasso's Les Demoiselles d'Avignon, for example, captured the "new beauty" of machines and industrial power.

2. The Great Depression's Influence on Themes of Poverty and Struggle

The economic depression of the 1930s significantly influenced themes of social injustice and class disparities. Social Realism became the order of the day, as artists aimed to bring forth stark realities of poverty, struggle for labor, and resistance. Dorothea Lange's photographs, among so many others, and particularly the Migrant Mother series, documented the desperation of families facing hardship and, by implication, falling American agricultural industry. The photographs became visual representations of the Depression's soul-crushing impact on humanity, helping to shape public opinion and policy.

Regionalism was a movement that emphasized the values and lifestyle of rural America, also mined for this. Artists Grant Wood, famous for American Gothic, and Thomas Hart Benton sought to celebrate the "glory" aspect of rural America, contrasting the adversity experienced by the urban people of industrialization. In their work, they used exaggerated figures and simplified forms to depict scenes of everyday life, which people related to because they were going through similar experiences. This motivation was not only a matter of identity for the artists, connected the disparities between city wealth and country poverty.

Modern Art and the Emergence of Psychological and Philosophical Thoughts:

Modernism's own mark of its evolution to the innovative works in psychology and philosophy at the turn of the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Freudian psychoanalysis, for example, rarely [illegible] public perception of the human mind, pushing deeply explore the subconscious, dreams, and repressed desires. These ideas gave rise to movements like Surrealism, which the artists used to translate the illogical and irrational qualities of the subconscious into the canvas. Among others, Salvador Dalí, René Magritte, and Max Ernst used bizarre and symbolic imagery to show the hidden depths of the psyche. From Modernism to Contemporary: How Psychology Shaped Modern Art? This approach marked the shifting of emphasis away from the act of representation of the visible world to the inner landscape of the psyche. Philosophy also took the lead as modern art

Existentialism, popularized by Jean-Paul Sartre and Friedrich Nietzsche, for example, encouraged the individual to confront the fluidity of life and create his or her meaning in a meaningless world ("Existentialism in Modern Art - Modern Art Terms and Concepts"). Such thoughts moved artists to utilize abstract forms or shapes, and they prioritized highly introspective, almost emotionally abstract output. Artists like Mark Rothko and Jackson Pollock made use of non-representational forms and emotional intensity to capture the deep questions of existence. This interplay of psychology and philosophy not only pushed the boundaries of creativity, but also allowed artists to interact with art on a deeper, more personal level. Modern art became more than just a visual experience; it was now a medium for exploring the complexities of human thought, emotion, and identity.

Breaking Away from Tradition: The Rebellion of Modern Art:

The spirit of rebellion, to break away from the rigidity of traditional conventions of art, lies at the heart of modern art. Before the era of Modernism, art was largely organized by rigid academic standards, focusing on realism, proportion, and harmony. However, facing with the world's profound transformations in the social, political, and technological spheres of life, artists began challenging these traditions in search of new ways to express themselves.

Movements such as Impressionism, Cubism, and Fauvism were among the early first to break boundaries. For instance, Impressionism distinguished itself by focusing on fleeting details and social compositions, capturing the ever-changing effects of light and atmosphere.

Cubism, the Dada Pioneer and Georges Braque fragmented objects into geometrical shapes and showed several views of an object in a single frame. Pieces included Henri Matisse, who used bright, saturated colors to emphasize feeling over the naturalistic appearance of things. They advocated for ideas that are bad to human reality, embracing abstraction and experimentation instead. This was not only a rebellion against traditional techniques. The Bilbaoed Age, individualism, and decentralization of culture happened around the time the Surrealists between "high art" and the periphery. Such a shift allowed society to interpret the world subjectively, challenging Pop Art was the world beyond new and different perspectives. By rejecting tradition, modern art became a powerful expression of freedom and transformation. It transformed art into a dynamic, ever-evolving field that embraced diversity in expression. This legacy of the past laid the groundwork for the artistic experimentation and creativity that continues to define contemporary art today.

The Globalization of Modern Art

1. Cross-Cultural Influences

Globalization has facilitated an unprecedented exchange of artistic ideas between different parts of the world and, in turn, enriched them with a plethora of ideas and techniques. Artists have been able to incorporate traditional techniques and imagery from other cultures into their work.

For example, the incorporation of African and Asian aesthetic into Western art has produced new styles and representations of an increasingly globalized world.

2. Modern Art Movements around the World

The 20th century saw many artists participate that reflect a global blending of ideas and styles. For example, Cubism, developed in France as Cubism had been established by the artistic influence of African sculpture and masks to break down forms and perspective. Surface Tension Learning.

- Abstract Expressionism: Originating in the United States, this movement emphasized individuality and the use of abstract forms, focusing on spontaneous, dynamic ways to express personal feelings (Ashton, 2000).

- Pop Art: Originated in the UK and the US, Pop Art used images from popular culture, mixing fine art with commercial imagery. It reflected a global consumer culture (Hibbitt, 2000).

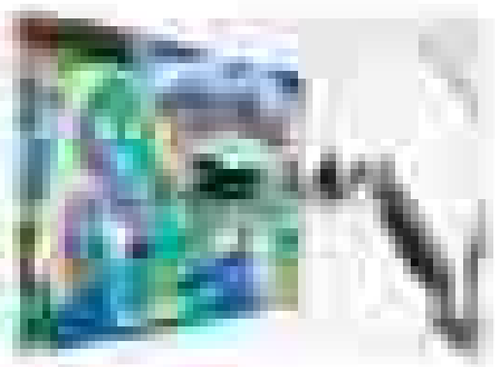
Contemporary, in fact, show how globalization has affected artists in various ways. It has created a dynamic and global art scene, where cross-cultural influences are commonplace. Artists draw inspiration from various aspects of cultures, thus making art diverse and global. It is necessary the globalization of modern art has fostered a more inclusive and diverse artistic dialogue, where cross-cultural influences are commonplace. Artists draw inspiration from various aspects of cultures, thus making art diverse and global.

Urbanization and Industrialization in Modern Art:

Urbanization and industrialization significantly influenced modern art, leading artists to explore themes of progress, alienation, and the social impact of technological advancements. Here's a concise overview:

1. ***Depiction of Urban Life: Symbols of Progress and Alienation***
   - Urban Realism: Artists portrayed the daily lives of city dwellers, highlighting both the vibrancy and challenges of urban existence.
   - Impressionist Cityscapes: Impressionists captured fleeting moments in urban settings, emphasizing the transient nature of modern life.
   - Expression of Isolation: Works depicting individuals amidst crowded environments, reflecting feelings of loneliness and alienation.
2. ***Industrial Landscapes: Reflections of Modern Social Conditions***
   - Factory Images: Depictions of industrial sites showcased the scale of industrialization and its impact on the environment.
   - Labor Representation: Artworks focusing on workers highlighted the human element within industrial settings.
   - Environmental Impact: Some illustrating the manifestation of rural areas into industrial landscapes.
3. ***Technology's Effect on Artistic Expression and Social Critique***
   - Adoption of New Techniques: Artists experimented with new materials and methods inspired by technological advancements.
   - Critique of Mechanization: Artworks expressing concerns over the dehumanizing aspects of technology.
   - Altered Perceptions: Showcasing how the Industrial Revolution transformed the relationship between humans and their surroundings.

These themes reflect how modern artists responded to the rapid changes brought about by urbanization and industrialization, aiming their work to comment on and critique contemporary society.



The Influence of Technology on Modern Art:

Modern art is heavily influenced by advancements in technology. With each new medium and technique made available through innovation, artists pushed boundaries. From photography to film and digital art, and to artificial intelligence, are the many changes that technology has brought into forms of artistic expression.

1. ***Photography's Impact on Painting and the Birth of New Art Forms***

Photography was invented in the 19th century and rapidly changed the creation of modern art. Up until then, painting was a major way of documenting reality. However, when photography came along, artists did not have to concern themselves with realistic portraits anymore. It was this shift that allowed for movements like

Impressionism in music, where the emphasis of mood and emotion rather than the precise details was to be formed recognizing in (Nicolle, 2004).

An essential because more available to the public, painters gave way to cellphone photographs in their work and both Cubism and Surrealism were born. Photographers also began to experiment artistically and instruments like film Ray provided unusual and dream photographs (Lanier Lanning, n.d.).

2. The Digital Revolution: From Computer Graphics to AI Art

The late 20th century saw the emergence of digital art. Tools such as Adobe Photoshop and 3D modeling software allowed artists to manipulate images in unprecedented ways. Digital artists like David Hockney, who moved away from traditional painting to the iPad creation of an, continue to push boundaries (Cornell, 2024). Nowadays, the rise of artificial intelligence and its applications has brought with it machine generated art, raising questions about creativity and authorship. AI-generated artworks, including works made with programs like DALL-E and Midjourney, complicate the notion of artistic skill and originality (Mitchell, 2023).

3. The Aesthetics of Social Media and the Democratization of Art

Social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok have allowed artists to reach global audiences without traditional gallery representation. This has led to the rise of digital artists, meme creators, and citizen-based artistic activism (Lanpaid, 2023). The accessibility of these platforms has enlarged how artists engage with audiences, making art more interactive and participatory.

Political Art & Activism:

Political art has frequently served as a vehicle for political expression, challenging authority and sparking social movements. Artists use various mediums to critique systems, advocate for change, and document historical events.

1. Art as a Response to War and Oppression

Historically, political art has flourished in response to conflict. Picasso's Guernica (1937) is one of the most famous examples, depicting the horrors of the Spanish Civil War. Similarly, Goya's art in the early 19th century underscoring and aims to critique the devastation caused by World War I (McCully, 2024). During the Civil War, Soviet artists used underground art to resist government propaganda, while American artists engaged in civil war protests through posters and installations (Urban Art Guide, 2014).

2. Street Art and Protest Movements

The late 20th and early 21st centuries have seen a rise in street art as a form of political activism. Artists such as Banksy use graffiti to challenge issues like capitalism, war, and environmental exploitation. In the Middle East, street art became a crucial tool for protest during the Arab Spring, as murals in the streets of cities served as visual commentary on political upheaval (Lanpaid, n.d.).

3. Digital Art and Online Activism

In the contemporary era, political art has extended beyond physical spaces. Digital artists utilize virtual platforms to raise awareness and mobilize support for political causes such as climate change, racial justice, and human rights. Digital activism movements, including Black Lives Matter, have leveraged digital art like visually impactful posters that highlight

[illegible] approach (Lanpech, 2019).

Initiatives on platforms like NFT [illegible] models for social justice issues, battling climate [illegible] lost biodiversity and activists interact to [illegible] art (NRDC, 2018).

Conclusion:

As climate change and environmental degradation have emerged as pressing global concerns, modern art has responded by incorporating sustainability and ecological themes. Many artists now use recycled or organic materials to draw attention to the consequences of consumerism and waste, installations and conceptual pieces often invite viewers to reflect on humanity's impact on the natural world. Cecilia Vicuña's works, for example, combine the fragility of nature through [illegible] installations like "Lo Quick," which [illegible] plastic bags to demonstrate climate change. Such projects become not just a powerful medium for environmental activism.

While modern art often blends from traditional spaces, it also frequently engages in a dialogue with history, [illegible] classics from past artists and reinterpreting them through a contemporary lens. Postmodern artists like [illegible] are critical of purists and purely. Mixing old and new to present the very sense of art. This synthesis of tradition and innovation reflects [illegible] identity—[illegible] honors its heritage while pushing creative boundaries. Through this blend, artists continue to challenge perceptions and expand the possibilities of artistic expression.

Resources:

[illegible] and materials used: "GIF/The French Revolution And Its Global Impact"

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Chapter 6

Media & Communication Revolutions